



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 32

NEW JERSEY

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside New Jersey's family courts and child-welfare system.

37

NEW JERSEY FAMILIES ON RECORD ·
60 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 16
MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF
PARENTING TIME

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 25, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
11 OF 21

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

NEW JERSEY AT A GLANCE.

Across 37 New Jersey families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 60 37 of 37 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$30,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 16 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 62.2% 40.5% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 37	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.6	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 37 of 37	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 11

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so New Jersey families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF NEW JERSEY FAMILY COURT

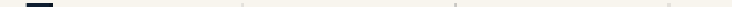
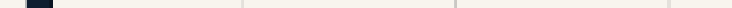
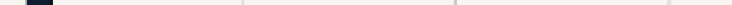
Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

Expense Category	Responses	Median	Mean	Total Reported
Attorney Fees	24	\$30,000	\$80,000	\$1,920,000
Lost Wages	21	\$20,000	\$79,052	\$1,660,100
Other Court Fees	19	\$2,000	\$23,453	\$445,600
Therapy / Evaluations	20	\$4,250	\$11,692	\$233,850
Reunification Services	13	\$0	\$2,077	\$27,000
GAL Fees	15	\$0	\$1,233	\$18,500
Asset Loss ¹	24	\$55,000	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$111,250	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$55,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME - MONTHS

Median months lost		16	1.3 yrs
Mean months lost		22	1.8 yrs
Total across all families		555	46.2 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · NEW JERSEY

Most families documenting in New Jersey are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Not provided		18	49%
Active case: stuck or delayed		11	30%
Case closed: within last 2 years		3	8%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		2	5%
I am not currently in court but still affected		1	3%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		15	41%
Family Court Only		14	38%
Unknown		7	19%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		1	3%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

Over 10 years		8	22%
5 – 10 years		7	19%
3 – 5 years		6	16%
1 – 3 years		5	14%
5+ years		4	11%

CUSTODY STATUS

50/50 Joint		15	41%
Full Custody		6	16%
Visitation Only		6	16%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access		6	16%
Partial / Shared		3	8%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Morris		4	11%
Atlantic		2	5%
Bergen		2	5%
Camden		2	5%
Burlington		2	5%
Middlesex		1	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		10	27%
High Conflict Divorce		6	16%
Other: (Short answer)		5	14%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		3	8%
Environmental/Poverty-Related (Lack of housing, utilities, etc.)		2	5%

05 PARENT VOICES — NEW JERSEY

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



Institutional Betrayed my children and myself with fake justice and no interest in being impartial. I am deaf Latina who doesn't speak English our abuser is deaf American born but nevertheless court has allowed his paralegal wife interfere and participate for him fully even [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Took my children away based on a biased report without due process, dismissing the documented abuse. Permitted post separation abuse in the court for over a decade

— NEW JERSEY PARENT · COLLEEN

MORE VOICES FROM NEW JERSEY

Child support against my constitution rights tl with no jurisdiction and. hey're went against and siderb with false dyfs calls

— JOEY

Allowed a known abuser to put a survivor on the street and cause homelessness and take her children who endured every ounce of the abuse with her and leave them in the care of the person who caused the trauma and now uses them to exploit others, as weapons to hurt their mother [...]

— CATHERINE

Morris County and Judge Bogaard has destroyed my children and I financially emotionally and physically they protect abusers. My exhusband has friends that are politically connected and law-enforcement. They are all sons of Italy bothers. They are all working together selling [...]

— ISABELLA

Family court is criminal, destroyed my family, with no contact to my 2 grown children who still live with their father who is a lawyer. I learned family court law, wrote my own motions after 5 years of over \$100,000+ wasted on both sides and became ProSe.

— LORI

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The court took my two little best friends and tried to turn them against me! It's destroying parents but siblings too!

— AMANDA

I was threatened by CPS that they would take my children for neglect if I didn't leave the physically abusive marriage, and when I left and filed a restraining order, the Court forced visitation that was "supervised" by his brother. I now have to send my youngest child to visit [...]

— KRISTIN

Torn US apart - separated us I was a stay at home Mother housewife and homemaker.

— BARBARA

I thought the court system is meant to protect us, but it did the contrary, it destroyed us.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Lost my home, 2 businesses, career, daughter now 11 in treatments for AMPS which can't be cured and primary compromised immune system so can't be in school. My child's life was destroyed with blatant lies, perjury, and malicious acts.

— CARRIE

No enforcement, judge stated multiple times "why is this case never settled. I'm not dealing with child support enforcement. Figure it out." Divorced with a 4 page binding agreement and no MSA. The judge would make a decision with a court order that would never be addressed in [...]

— ROBIN

Financial bankruptcy, homeless , living in a vehicle

— RAYIF

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

*Separated all of us from each other*

— LISA

The system treated me, Their mother as a criminal. Although Instead of innocent until proven guilty: I was treated guilty and went bankrupt trying to prove my innocence. Truth didn't matter neither did the wellbeing of my kids.

— KRISTA

My son was mercilessly kidnapped I lost my son for 4 years put into kinship placement with out my knowledge

— MAUREEN

Defamation of character and the introduction of the system to my 5 year old only based on anonymous retaliatory allegations

— THERESA

Created extensive delay of divorce with a high conflict other parent who continues their abuse post-separation. The marriage was emotionally, mentally abusive(& more), and the court allows him to continue abuse via financial and manipulation, due to the court's lack of action.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They don't look at my evidence I've been begging court that we can't coparent for years and they told me we need to learn however, my ex does not want to hate me and uses the kids as weapons

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Broken us and broken a beautiful boy away from a loving fully dedicated mother

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system is being very biased. I explain to the court how the child is being used as a weapon to hurt me by the other party & they are doing nothing about it. I try to request more time other party objects and the court granted her objection. I been the one filing for 4 years [...]

— CHRISITAN

The system has destroyed the well bring and emotion state of my family. It has completely alienated my daughter from me and forced my oldest son to be alienated from his father and his family. It has systematically broken us. We live in constant PTSD and live to defend and [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

The system is so skewed for people with higher income or those who know someone in the courts or have some sort of power of their own. Poor, hard working people usually pay dearly, well off people that are abusive do not.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

23 New Jersey parents submitted ranked quotes. 23 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/nj.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this New Jersey report comes from New Jersey respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in New Jersey — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 37 New Jersey families reporting here are not the universe of New Jersey families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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